to the Tibetan king. From Nepal came Princess Bhrikuti as his other celebrated consort. The two royal brides are credited with introducing Buddhism to Tibet. The Jokhang temple in Lhasa and the Potala royal palace date from this period. Srongtsen Gampo is also credited with the introduction of the distinctive Tibetan script. He sent his minister Thonmi Sambhota to India along with sixteen young scholars to learn Sanskrit and to create a script based on the Brahmi/Gupta script then prevalent in north India.

The Tibetan empire continued to flourish and expand during the reigns of Srongsten Gampo's successors, in particular Trisong Detsen (755–797 CE) and Ralpacan (817–836 CE). During this 200-year period, the Tibetan empire not only dominated the Tibetan plateau, but extended south across the Himalayan crescent, east towards Yunnan province, west up to the Pamirs and north to the Tsaidam Basin and the Kokkonur lake region. This area would cover present-day Xinjiang and Qinghai provinces in China, parts of both Inner Mongolia in China and the Mongolian People's Republic, as well as substantial parts of the Chinese provinces of Sichuan and Yunnan.

In 751 CE , the Tibetans allied together with the Muslim Arab tribes in present-day Xinjiang to defeat the Tang forces in the battle of Talas (in modern Kazakhstan). With this defeat the Tang empire lost the oasis towns of Central Asia, which resulted in the interruption of the caravan trade. The Tang capital of Changan itself was attacked and plundered by Tibetan forces in 763 CE and the emperor had to flee to safety. It was the Tibetans who imposed peace on their terms claiming regular tribute. A treaty was concluded in 783 CE , which is recorded on a pillar in front of the Potala palace in Lhasa. It conveys clearly that this was a treaty between equals rather than an alliance between an overlord and a vassal:

> Tibet and China shall abide by the frontiers of which they are now in occupation. All to the east is the country of great China; all to the west is, without question, the country of great Tibet. This solemn agreement has established an epoch when Tibetans shall be happy in the land of Tibet and the Chinese in the land of China. [1]

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